

Rapid #: -27011160

CROSS REF ID: **5944631720005514**

LENDER: **UZBUAOI (UB Zürich, Asien-Orient) :: Main Library**

BORROWER: **HESSO_RS (HESSO_Resource Sharing Library) :: Main Library**

TYPE: Article CC:CCL

JOURNAL TITLE: Bulletin of the School of Oriental and African Studies

USER JOURNAL TITLE: Bulletin of the School of Oriental and African Studies

ARTICLE TITLE: John Picton and John Mack: African textiles: looms, weaving and design. Second edition. 208 pp. London: British Museum Publications, 1989. £11.95.

ARTICLE AUTHOR: Moore, Elizabeth

VOLUME: 54

ISSUE: 1

MONTH:

YEAR: 1991

PAGES: 231 - 232

ISSN: 0041-977X

OCLC #:

Processed by RapidX: 6/25/2026 7:47:04 AM

-



Volume LIV
1991

BULLETIN
OF THE
SCHOOL OF
ORIENTAL AND
AFRICAN STUDIES
UNIVERSITY OF LONDON

Published by
THE SCHOOL OF ORIENTAL AND AFRICAN STUDIES

© School of Oriental and African Studies
University of London 1992

UK ISSN 0041—977X

Printed in England by Stephen Austin and Sons, Ltd.,
Caxton Hill, Hertford

gatherers. They deserve a place in the libraries of all universities offering anthropology as an academic major.

A. TERRY RAMBO

JOHN PICTON AND JOHN MACK: *African textiles: looms, weaving and design. Second edition.* 208 pp. London: British Museum Publications, 1989. £11.95.

This is the second edition of *African textiles*, the first having been printed in 1979. The book is valuable for both specialists and non-specialists, and in the case of the reviewer, will provide a standard against which to measure works on South-East Asian textiles. The text offers a very detailed account of the processes of handwoven textile manufacture and finishing in Africa. As the authors point out, many stages of the weaving, dyeing, and decoration of these textiles rely on 'mechanical principles [which] are simple in practice though difficult to describe in words' (p. 95). Picton and Mack have addressed this problem both visually and textually.

In the first instance, nearly every double page spread is illustrated. There are over sixty colour and 130 black and white photographs reproduced, many either full (8½" × 11") or half page, remarkable in a book of 208 pages selling at just under twelve pounds. The six maps show the relevant information without being cluttered with excess detail. (As it is probably the only criticism I shall find to air, I would have preferred to have all the maps in a group either at the beginning or end of the book.)

The text has been formatted in a single column which occupies only two-thirds of the page width. This visual device facilitates both a careful reading of the words, and use of the book as a reference to what precisely occurs when a textile is made. It is in its highly detailed but spare style of exposition, that the volume provides an academically quotable source of information. This tone is established in the introductory chapter, where definitions of 'textile', 'fabric' and 'cloth' are given. Textiles are woven fabrics or fibrous constructions. Non-woven fabrics, such as felt and barkcloth, lack the pre-requisite 'interworking of previously prepared elements' (p. 17) necessary to qualify a textile. The commonly used 'cloth' muddies the seemingly neat dichotomy between textiles and fabrics: 'All textiles are cloths, but not all cloths are textiles, for they need not be woven; and all cloths are fabrics, but, again, not all fabrics are cloths' (p. 18). This verbal cul-de-sac is opened with reference to Irene Emery, who distinguishes between cloth and basketry, noting the absence of rigid elements in the former, a characteristic which generally determines the relatively limited pliability of the latter.

Careful use of terminology, and attempts to clarify previous confusions arising from ambiguous word use, are found throughout the text. For example, in ch. v, 'The double-heddle loom', the term 'pit loom' is criticized: its lack of relevance to the process of cloth production being demonstrated by the existence of both single and double-heddle looms in areas ranging

from north-east Africa to eastern Yorubaland that incorporate some type of pit into the setup of the loom. It is the loom design rather than its vertical or horizontal positioning, the type of weave, or sex of the weaver, that Picton and Mack have selected to classify the textiles of Africa. The loom holds the warp element of the textile-to-be in tension, an improvement over right-angle interlacing of limp threads. Likewise, the addition of a second heddle, or shedding device to draw apart alternate threads of the warp to permit insertion of the weft, allows greatly increased productivity.

Description of the elements common to any loom, the types of weaves which are possible, is followed by two detailed chapters on the distribution of single- and double-heddle looms in Africa, and the types of textiles produced on them. The bulk of the material on single-heddle and double-heddle weaving is organized by groups of people. Thus for the single-heddle loom, the authors specify the loom structure and steps in the weaving process found among Moroccan Berber and Nigerian Yoruba groups. In both cases, the users of the single-heddle loom are women. One item produced by Berber women is woven to a semi-circular shape. The cloth is then stitched by men to make a cloak. Although this loom is mounted vertically, Berber women also employ horizontally-mounted, single-heddle looms for weaving tent-cloths. In Nigeria, however, women's weaving is restricted to a vertically-mounted, single-heddle loom, whereas Nigerian men use a double-heddle horizontal structure. An interesting point brought up in the discussion of women's weaving in Yoruba areas of Nigeria is its uneven survival. In many areas, the availability of factory-woven textiles has replaced demand for the cotton cloths made by women in the past for clothing. However, where the cloth has 'prestige or ritual value, or because it can be sold for cash', the vertical single-heddle loom is still in use. In instances where, at least in the late 1960s, women continued to weave, demand came from several sources. Among Ebirra women, for example, woven cloth was used for wrapping corpses, for masquerade, for sale elsewhere in Nigeria to be used on deckchairs, and for rough clothing (p. 77).

The information on the textiles produced on double-heddle looms in Africa is equally detailed, achieving the authors' stated aim of showing 'something of the variety of pattern and texture achieved with a relatively restricted range of weave structures' (p. 96). As for the single-heddle looms, examples of the products of the double-heddle looms are organized by groups: the Mende of Sierra Leone; the Bamana, Fulani, Djerna and other weavers of Mali; the Hausa, Nupe and Yoruba peoples of Nigeria; and the Asante and Ewe of Ghana. Among the Asante, weaving technique has been highly developed, primarily in the context of an elite demand, which has declined in post-colonial Ghana.

Weaving in Madagascar is discussed separately (ch. vi). This covers loom types, including variations of the single-heddle loom such as the backstrap loom, not found elsewhere in an African context. The different types of Malagasy cloth are summarized. The preparation of the raw materials for these tex-

tiles, and those of the African mainland, are described in detail in an earlier section on raw materials (ch. ii). All dyeing of textiles on Madagascar, until recently including warp 'ikat', is carried out before weaving.

This is in contrast to the rest of Africa, where a number of techniques are used to dye cloth after weaving. This forms the subject of a separate chapter, 'Pattern dyeing', which describes resist-dyed cloths, in particular the *adire* cloths of the Yoruba. Other methods of putting a liquid on a cloth to achieve a pattern are grouped in 'Drawn, painted, printed and stencilled patterns' (ch. viii). This chapter and the next, 'Applique and related techniques', are organized by method rather than group, a logical decision as these topics are treated in less detail than is the case for the process of producing the textile. The final chapter is on embroidery. The authors include interesting details of Islamic influences on embroidered cloth, and the Kuba technique of 'cut pile' embroidery. Finally, the book contains both bibliography and index.

African textiles covers a great deal of material. The authors' emphasis on technical processes makes this volume of use as a general reference for anyone interested in textiles, while its careful and up-dated documentation of African weaving practices, make its second edition welcome. Lastly, it is a pleasure to look at.

ELIZABETH MOORE

RICHARD TERRELL: *West African interlude: a retrieval of personal experience.* 175 pp. Salisbury: Michael Russell, 1988.

Richard Terrell joined the Colonial Office in 1946, shortly before his 38th birthday. Early in 1951 he went to Nigeria for two years, as a temporary member of the administrative service there, an early beneficiary of a rather imaginative scheme for sending Colonial Office staff abroad for practical experience in the colonies. He was, it seems, 'the youngest grandfather known to have been sent to West Africa on a training exercise'. The book is largely based on a personal private journal kept, somewhat intermittently, during the period 1946 to 1952, at which time the author returned to England.

It is a short book, interesting, even evocative, sometimes amusing, rather chatty, an easy read. It is full of stimulating ideas and reflections, none elaborated much beyond a page or two, but well worth reading and savouring. There are observations on the Colonial Office, a rather authoritarian 'department of doers as well as observers and diplomats' (p. 14), including an interesting comparison with international agencies (p. 20); the volume is dedicated 'to the memory of the British Colonial Office whose impact upon events in recent decades is due for reappraisal'. The 'extraordinary years of euphoria' under the post-war Labour government, with all kinds of new colonial initiatives implying 'vigorous bureaucratization everywhere' (pp. 16-7), are described. Pay was hardly an incentive: 'in those days an officer's preparedness to incur debts was a test of his dedication to the service' (p. 29). Contrasts are

drawn between government administration in Whitehall and Nigeria, and the implications of these for the survival of parliamentary democracy. There is commentary on various early development projects, including eggs and poultry in the Gambia, almost all disastrous failures, and on Community Development as a possible alternative. Nigerian topics range from local elections to censuses, from polygamy to spiders. The author sums up the colonial experience in Nigeria: 'Whatever the truth about past [colonial] exploitation, in my own period little of it remained. On every side could be seen evidence of positive achievement, welcomed by Africans at all levels. I was more concerned about the cold remoteness of our lives than about the value of our mission' (p. 97). Coverage is inevitably fragmentary. Terrell did not, it seems, make much effort to explore for example the richness of Nigerian Christian experience: 'Protestant missionaries were seldom successful among Africans... The only Protestant converts I encountered in my Nigerian life were gloomy teetotalers, single men or disconsolate monogamists' (p. 53). Such tunnel vision is happily rare in the book.

There is also a good deal of personal chat, about servants, and the car breaking down, and so forth, deftly and entertainingly done. And, woven throughout the volume, there is a visible strand of personal psychological stress, apparently sometimes profound. The author rightly refers to 'a continuum of self-exposure which could not be excised without making the result artificial'. He continues: 'In order to counter questions which the discerning reader is bound to ask, I must reveal certain features of personal history which are not relevant to my main purpose. A few years after the adventures described below there was a breakdown in my married life. This did not occur suddenly' (p. 23). The marriage breakdown is the only feature mentioned here, but the story was evidently not quite as simple as that, and the reference to 'the discerning reader' seems almost designed to ginger up our interest and attention. The author's states of mind range from very happy to deeply wretched (p. 23), he is prey to a variety of (sometimes quite irrational) fears (pp. 27, 30, 33, 58). A plaguing nervous and emotional tension is mentioned, but then set aside: 'the stream of imagery belongs more fittingly to a psychiatric clinic than to the kind of memoir I wish to record' (pp. 34-5). 'What am I here for? Secretly, to see the silky, ebony smiles of the women...' (p. 59). Leisure 'comes in a savagery of loneliness. I fight against the futility of lust and read Gibbon through hot evenings' (p. 60). 'I hope the sun boils us on the march—that food is bad, mosquitoes a plague and water filthy. Oh, to scourge the hell within me' (pp. 71-2). Terrell fell in love (but did not interfere) with the companion of his steward: 'I cannot look at Anise without wanting to kiss her, which is impossible. This is torture' (p. 91). Finally, the steward, at his own initiative (and not to protect Anise, whose place had already been taken by another woman) introduced his 'masta' to an African woman, Christiana, whom Terrell took instantly to be his mistress.

What does it all mean? The third sentence in the book (apart from acknowledgements)